

Brookline Advisory Committee
Public Safety Subcommittee
Fire Department FY22 Budget Review

The Public Safety Subcommittee held a virtual public hearing on the Brookline Fire Department (BFD) FY22 Operating Budget on Thursday, February 25, 2021 at 5:30 PM. Attending from the Subcommittee: Janice Kahn (Chair), Alisa Jonas, David-Marc Goldstein, Susan Granoff and Neil Gordon. Also in attendance: Chief John Sullivan, Kevin Mascoll (Public Safety Business Manager), Assistant Town Administrator Justin Casanova-Davis, Carla Benka (AC), Select Board Member John VanScoyoc, Paul Trahon (Local 950), Mike Toffel (TMM P8), Kristine Knauf (TMM P15), Fred Levitan, Karl Knauf, Nancy O'Connor (Parks & Rec Commission).

Budget Summary: The request for the FY22 BFD operating budget is \$16,481,472 which is an increase of \$159,716 (0.97%) from FY21. Most of that increase comes from Salaries which increases \$130,562 (0.82%) due to additional staff (\$126,778) and longevity pay (\$4,500). The Services line item increases \$17,000 (10.9%) due to transitioning to a new records management system, and the Utilities line item increases \$12,154 (5.40%) due to increases in gasoline (\$3,065) and diesel (\$14,232), which is slightly offset by decreases in electricity (\$1,603), natural gas (\$2,460) and generator fuel (\$576). Also note that Budgeted Capital was reduced by about \$95K in FY21 and remains at that reduced level. Equipment, usually bought on a rotating replacement basis, such as SCBA, was put on a more extended replacement schedule which will have to be addressed in the near future.

Expand All	FY20 Actual	FY21 Budget	FY22 Budget	2021-22 Variance	2021-22 Variance
► SALARIES	\$ 15,362,728	\$ 15,734,789	\$ 15,865,351	130,562	0.82%
► SERVICES	114,744	151,426	168,426	17,000	10.09%
► SUPPLIES	138,690	126,952	126,952	0	0.00%
► OTHER	28,851	27,100	27,100	0	0.00%
► UTILITIES	196,832	212,883	225,037	12,154	5.40%
► BUDGETED CAPITAL	263,298	68,606	68,606	0	0.00%
Total	\$ 16,105,142	\$ 16,321,756	\$ 16,481,472	159,716	0.97%

Data filtered by EXPENSES, GENERAL FUND, FIRE and exported on March 7, 2021. Created with OpenGov

Discussion:

Emergency Management Sub-Program: Chief Sullivan has since July 2019 served as the Town's emergency management (EM) director. Starting in FY21 the Emergency Management Sub-program was established within the BFD to coordinate "all local emergency planning, preparedness, response mitigation

and recovery” from both natural and human-caused disasters. It centralizes the administration of the various EM functions of the Town including preparing and maintaining the Emergency Operations Plan, the staffing of the Emergency Operations Center (located at the Municipal Service Center on Hammond Street), and coordination of the Local Emergency Planning Committee, and the Citizens Emergency Response Teams (CERT) and the Emergency Preparedness Buddies Program.

Cheryl Snyder, the part-time emergency response coordinator for the Health Department, has joined the BFD as the emergency management coordinator. Last March the BFD received a UASI grant (\$140K) to hire a full-time coordinator under the director of EM. The grant covered costs in years FY2020 and FY2021; the FY2022 budget includes \$36K to cover the costs of this position once the grant monies run out.

Covid-19 Impact on the BFD: Only about 20 members of the FD contracted Covid, but in April/May of last year about 44 of the 153 firefighters were unable to work and needed to be quarantined due to potential or actual exposure to the virus. To minimize the risk of entire companies being quarantined, Chief Sullivan divided companies into subgroupings. To keep these groupings separated, some were placed in temporary housing in the Main (Village) Public Library and in the Florida Ruffin Ridley School in Coolidge Corner for a month while those buildings were not open to the public. Cambridge Health Alliance provided free Covid-testing, with quick results, as well as contact tracing, consultation and vaccinations. Vaccination is voluntary, not mandated, but through an education effort to-date @85% of the firefighters have been vaccinated.

Covid-19 demands made this a very difficult year, but a cooperative effort between the FD and Local 950 helped make the BFD a model and resource for other fire departments in the area. There was a suspension of all personal and vacation days and swaps during April and May. The BFD had to adjust first responder response protocols to limit exposures to the virus.

The Town was able to quickly establish an emergency management team of people from many departments who volunteered their time to come to the EOC to help with the Brookline Call Center to answer questions from residents and to assist with issues such as logistics and procurement.

Records Management System (RMS): As of December 2021 the current version of FireHouse software will no longer be supported. The company that created FireHouse was bought by ESO Solutions, which has created their own RMS platform. In anticipation of having to replace the system, and after vetting multiple vendors, it was decided to go with ESO Solutions: (1) they currently own FireHouse software, which will make the portability of the data easier; (2) ESO Solutions offers an all-in-one package; (3) the Town was given a discount for the first year bringing the cost to \$17K in FY22, rising each year to about \$32K in year three. Other advantages are that eventually it will interface with the CAD (dispatch) system—which will need to be upgraded in the next few years—and interface with MUNIS for payroll as well. ESO also has the ability for firefighters to input data on tablets to put directly into the RMS, rather than the current system, which involves writing daily equipment checks onto a paper record that sits in a folder in a desk.

Vacancies: There are currently only 4 vacancies, but although the BFD is a very young department, 3-4 members are expected to retire over the next year or so. As a consequence, Chief Sullivan expects that in FY23 there will be a need to hold a class to train new recruits to fill about 8-9 vacancies. A comment received after the public hearing raised the issue of the need to have a line-item in the budget for training.

This has been an ongoing concern and point of discussion, particularly since the Town invested in building a new training and maintenance facility at Station 6 on Hammond Street.

Overtime: Overtime in the BFD is an issue, particularly when there are vacancies in the Department. Over the past year, overtime costs have been driven by the extraordinary demands placed on the BFD to respond to the pandemic. Some of the current \$92K deficit from overtime costs will be covered by CARES Act funds.

Consideration of Shift to In-house Ambulance Service: There hasn't been any further progress or study of this option due to Covid. The contract with Fallon Ambulance Company was renewed in July 2020 when we exercised our one-year option. They have been great partners during the past year's emergency according to Chief Sullivan; however, moving to an in-house ambulance service is still a viable option that needs further study. There would be substantial upfront costs, but might result in better and less costly ambulance service to the Town, given our proximity to the Longwood Medical Area.

Cancer Screening: Cancer is now the leading cause of death for retired firefighters. The BFD has been working on an expanded cancer screening initiative. The Department has a cancer awareness program and continues to provide information to members and is also initiating a program that would provide annual cancer screenings. HR Director Ann Braga is in the process of talking with different health provider groups about providing annual cancer checks and physicals to BFD members.

Racial Diversity and Inclusion: The BFD Union Local 950 has created a human relations committee to improve racial diversity and inclusion in the BFD, and wants to look at both racial and gender equity. The Department is working with Dr. Lloyd Gellineau, Director of the Town's Office of Diversity, Inclusion and Community Relations, on recruitment and interview methods to improve diversity.

By a vote of 5-0 the Public Safety Subcommittee unanimously recommends the budget of \$16,481,472 for the Fire Department in FY22.